gunmen roamed the old city of Nablus. If the first intifada gave the Palestinians fresh legitimacy on the world stage, the second stripped it away, prompting widespread condemnation. There was no formal end to the second intifada; instead it simply fizzled out in late 2004 and early 2005, after the death of Yasser Arafat, Israel's unilateral disengagement from Gaza, and the completion of large pieces of the separation barrier between Israel and the West Bank.

A decade later, conditions seemed ripe for another uprising. The Mitchell Report, a study of the Second Intifada prepared by former US senator and Dayton Accords negotiator George Mitchell, blamed the revolt on the failure of the Camp David talks in September 2000. By 2014, the "peace process" was stuck even more deeply in the mud. Bush had his "road map" and the Annapolis conference; Obama made several attempts at negotiations. None were successful. Settlements kept expanding, and the routine indignities and violence of occupation continued in the West Bank.

But those same conditions also augured against a third intifada. An exhausted and polarized Palestinian public no longer had prominent activists with enough influence to organize a grassroots uprising. The political leadership was divided, with Fatah controlling the West Bank and Hamas in charge of Gaza; both factions were seen as out-of-touch, self-interested, focused primarily on preserving their fiefdoms. Economic conditions in the West Bank had improved a bit, and Israel had relaxed some of its restrictions on internal movement, while the blockade of Gaza had turned that territory into a hermetically sealed, open-air prison.

So the topic became something of a running joke among the local press corps, the subject of breathless articles by foreign reporters parachuted into Jerusalem and Ramallah. There was no one to lead a third intifada, nor a public appetite for one. Violence was at historic lows. In the six-plus years between January 2009 and March 2015, Palestinian attackers killed fifty civilians inside Israel and the occupied territories—compared with 289 civilians in 2002 alone, at the height of the second intifada.[3]

"We live in shit already"

For a time during the winter of 2015, some residents of East Jerusalem started their mornings with a rush-hour queue at makeshift checkpoints manned by Israeli police. One woman died while waiting in line to reach a